

Psalms 58

Break Their Teeth, O God

Break their teeth, O God, in their mouth

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Do ye indeed speak righteousness, O congregation? do ye judge uprightly, O ye sons of men?*
- 2 *Yea, in heart ye work wickedness; ye weigh the violence of your hands in the earth.*
- 3 *The wicked are estranged from the womb: they go astray as soon as they be born, speaking lies.*
- 4 *Their poison is like the poison of a serpent: they are like the deaf adder that stoppeth her ear;*
- 5 *Which will not hearken to the voice of charmers, charming never so wisely.*
- 6 *Break their teeth, O God, in their mouth: break out the great teeth of the young lions, O LORD.*
- 7 *Let them melt away as waters which run continually: when he bendeth his bow to shoot his arrows, let them be as cut in pieces.*
- 8 *As a snail which melteth, let every one of them pass away: like the untimely birth of a woman, that they may not see the sun.*
- 9 *Before your pots can feel the thorns, he shall take them away as with a whirlwind, both living, and in his wrath.*
- 10 *The righteous shall rejoice when he seeth the vengeance: he shall wash his feet in the blood of the wicked.*
- 11 *So that a man shall say, Verily there is a reward for the righteous: verily he is a God that judgeth in the earth.*

2 · CONTEXT

A psalm confronting corrupt judges who "weigh violence" instead of righteousness, likely from David's experience of unjust rulers or courts. Henry treats the vivid imprecations (broken teeth, melting snails, untimely fruit) as poetic imagery for the collapse of organized wickedness under God's judgment, not literal cruelty to be imitated. MacArthur-style notes read verses 10–11 as assurance that visible justice vindicates God's moral government of the world.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

"Do ye indeed speak righteousness, O congregation?... ye weigh the violence of your hands." Corrupt leaders are addressed directly—injustice dressed as deliberation, violence carefully "weighed" rather than restrained.

Verse 3-5

The wicked are described as estranged from the womb, going astray "as soon as they be born," their venom likened to a serpent's, deaf to charming like the adder—a picture of deep-seated, willful corruption resistant to correction.

Verse 6-9

The famous imprecation: "Break their teeth, O God, in their mouth... Let them melt away as a snail... let them not see the sun." These are prayers that predatory power be disarmed and rendered harmless, not appeals for random cruelty.

Verse 10-11

"The righteous shall rejoice when he seeth the vengeance... Verily there is a reward for the righteous: verily he is a God that judgeth in the earth." Visible justice becomes cause for worship, confirming that God actively governs history, not merely eternity.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

When corrupt power seems entrenched and untouchable, Scripture permits honest prayer for its disarming, grounded in confidence that God actively "judgeth in the earth"—justice is not only a future hope but a present divine activity.

Application for life today.

Bring specific, corrupt structures or leaders before God honestly rather than suppressing anger at injustice; the psalm gives permission for strong prayer against organized evil. Resist despair that wickedness is permanent by remembering "verily there is a reward for the righteous." Let confirmed instances of justice in your own life or history become occasions of worship, not just relief.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What corrupt system or unjust "judge" in your world do you need to bring honestly before God, as this psalm does?

2. How does verse 11's claim that God actively "judgeth in the earth" challenge cynicism about justice ever arriving?

3. Where have you seen a small "reward for the righteous" that could become an occasion for praise?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).